



8-22-2023 MCS Board Meeting

Meeting Metadata	Details
Video Recording	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=mICipoUlj_4
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Municipal Meeting Report: Muncie Community Schools Board of Education

2. Meeting Identification & Attendance

- **Call to Order & Spoken Details:** The regular meeting of the Muncie Community Schools (MCS) Board of Education was called to order by the presiding officer.
- **Attendance:**
 - **Present:** Mr. Heater, Barnes Griffin, Mr. Irvin, Mr. Lowe, Dr. Bishop, O'Neill.
 - **Absent:** Mr. Williams.
 - **Presiding Officer:** Not explicitly named in the opening roll call, but Dr. Bishop and Mr. O'Neill led proceedings.

3. Preliminary & Procedural Business

- **Ceremonial Openings:** The meeting opened with a moment of silence followed by the recitation of the Pledge of Allegiance.
- **Approval of Minutes:** Prior meeting minutes disposition was handled via the consent agenda (Approved by Voice Vote).

4. Substantive Business & Board Action

- **01:19:38 Consent Agenda**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Board Administration / Dr. K
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Board reviewed general items, noting the upcoming retirement of Theresa Avila after 22 years of service.
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote.
- **01:20:25 Monthly Financial Report (July)**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Mr. Jerome (Chief Financial Officer)
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Presented the July financial results. Noted receipt of the state basic grant (estimated at roughly \$43.6 million, subject to fourth-quarter ADM counts). Total checkbook balance stood at over \$32.7 million, with the education fund balance over \$14.7 million (projected over \$15 million by year-end). The state loan is being paid down at \$50,000 monthly, increasing to \$150,000 late next year. Spending is tracking within approved appropriations.
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote.
- **01:23:21 ECA Stipends & Employee Payments List**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Mr. Jerome / Cabinet
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Annual presentation of Extra-Curricular Activities (ECA) stipends and other employee payments required by the State Board of accounts. Highlighted yellow-marked increases reflecting adjustments to support staff hourly wages (e.g., base support adjustments) and standardized substitute teacher pay at \$105/day. Developed in collaboration with principals and district leadership to ensure competitiveness.
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote.
- **01:26:11 Purchase Over \$100,000: i-Ready Assessment Partnership**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Administration
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Continuation of the partnership with i-Ready for beginning-, middle-, and end-of-year progress monitoring assessments in math and English for students. Funded primarily through the Indiana Assessment Grant (\$13/student split across math/English) and Title I funds. This marks the fourth year of utilizing the platform.
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote.
- **01:27:21 Reading Futures Program Agreement**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Heidi / Administration
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Virtual small-group reading intervention (tier 3 context) operating at Longfellow, Southview, and Grissom Elementary schools, serving 60

students last year with strong growth at Longfellow. Expanded to summer camp programming with the YMCA. Moving focus to grades 2 and 3 for the upcoming cohort, partnering with Ball State's Dr. Cassidy for research components, funded via School Improvement Grant funds.

- **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
- **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote.
- **01:36:38 Policy Review (First Reading / Batch Updates)**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Administration / Counsel (Amy Fox)
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Ongoing systematic review, updating, combination, and retirement of legacy district policies to align with updated Indiana state statutory codes.
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:** None.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote.

5. Open Public Comment / Citizen Forum

- **01:17:00 Ricky Yancer** (Resident & Author)
 - Addressed literacy and ILEARN testing scores, emphasizing that basic reading and math skills remain fundamental and must be elevated. Expressed views regarding local government taxation, spending, and cash reserves.
- **01:34:43 Ricky Yancer** (Second Speaker Turn during Budget Public Hearing)
 - Addressed the proposed 2024 budget public hearing, arguing that a school system with robust cash reserves should live within its means and exercise fiscal caution regarding property tax levies.

6. Administrative Updates & Adjournment

- **Staff / Board Announcements:**
 - **Rhonda Ward (Diversity & Equity Update):** Highlighted August diversity quotes, the introduction of the new "MCS Pledge" to be posted in all district buildings, cultural competency and poverty simulation training, Minority Educators Council (MEC) support groups, and upcoming HBCU college fairs, campus visits, and student field trips (including Step Africa and Minnetrista exhibits).
 - **Allison (Community Engagement & Wellness):** Reported an 875 approved volunteer count (a 30% increase), the rollout of "Big Idea Nights" focused on attendance and nutrition ("The Big Crunch"), expansion of Read United to all elementary schools, All-Pro Dads partnership expansion, Townsend corporate supply donations, and preliminary exploratory committee talks regarding public school Montessori options.
 - **Dr. Bell (Human Resources):** Outlined pillar two strategic updates on recruitment and retention. Highlighted an 84% teacher retention rate (highest post-COVID),

lower class sizes, teacher professional development initiatives, minority staff representation reaching 14%, transition-to-teaching pathways, and a newly structured, centralized HR attendance accountability process to address unpaid leave and chronic absenteeism.

- **Dr. K (CEO Updates):** Announced upcoming events including the Michelle and Jim Ryan Family Scholarship presentation, former UFC fighter Charlie “The Spaniard” Brenneman’s community speaking tour on grit and persistence, the ribbon-cutting ceremony for the new football and soccer stadium on Friday, a partnership with Muncie Civic Theatre for *Charlotte’s Web* at Southside, and receipt of a \$400,000 Stronger Connections Grant alongside a \$148,000 George and Francis Ball Foundation grant. Additionally noted that board school visits are being scheduled by Cindy.
- **Adjournment:** The meeting and public hearings were officially adjourned by voice vote.

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